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Racial Covenants in the Twin Cities

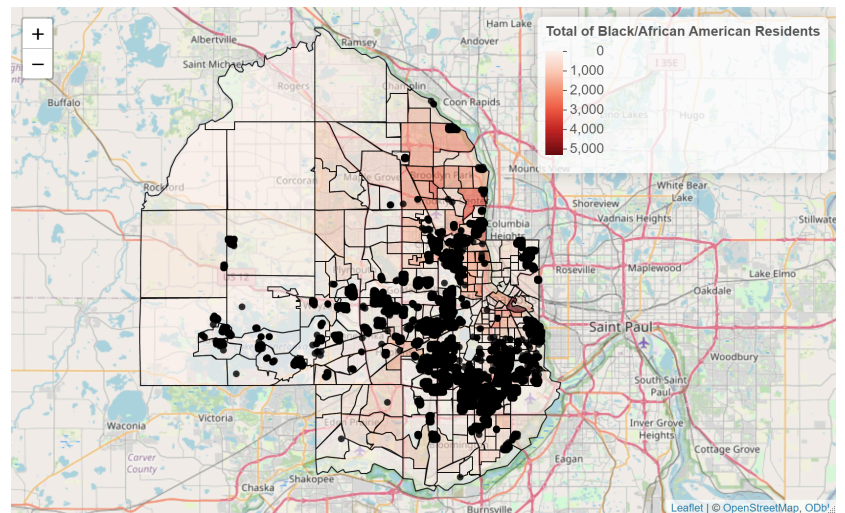
How has housing been historically racially discriminatory in Minneapolis-Saint Paul, and can we still see it today?

The practice of redlining in the United States has led to evident housing discrepancies across the country, but what if there were other housing factors that were also racially discriminatory? In many neighborhoods across America, racial covenants were used to restrict people of color from owning homes. Racial covenants are restrictive clauses of a housing deed which require that the property remain in the hands of white people. These clauses appeared in the 1920's, and remained popular in the US until the Fair Housing Act (FHA) was passed in 1968.

A geographical study was conducted by the Mapping Prejudice Project (MPP) to determine how racial covenants affected various counties in Minnesota. In Hennepin county, it was recorded that there were over 24,119 racial covenants. The majority of these covenants were implemented in the 1940's...but can we still see their effects today? The short answer is yes. In fact, Minnesota has one of the largest housing disparities in the nation.

Using this number and data collected from other Minnesota counties, MPP aims to explain the structural racism in Minnesota. We have used the data they gathered to further help visualize this inequality. We can see here the location of every racial covenant reported in Hennepin county. Through census data we also know the total number of Black/African American people in certain areas. When we look at these two data together, it becomes visible that there are less total Black/African American residents in areas with houses that previously had racial covenants.

Greenwood, a small, upscale lakeside community on the outer edge of Hennepin county, has the highest proportion of racial covenants to residents of any city in Hennepin county, with 1 covenant for every 3.5 of its 300 occupied houses. It also has one of the lowest proportions of black and African American residents. In 2010, only 4% of Greenwood homes were occupied by non-white residents, and only one of those homes was occupied by a black or African American resident. In 2020, the number of non-white residents had almost doubled, which is an impressive increase. It is important to note, however, that very small changes will naturally be amplified in such a localized setting, and none of those new non-white residents were black or African American. It is clear that Greenwood's legacy of racial covenants is still in place (but wavering) today. There are several factors that likely contribute to the slow undoing of that



legacy. Greenwood has a 90% rate of owner occupancy (rather than renter occupancy) and those owner occupied homes have a median value of 1.1 million dollars. Greenwood also has a median resident age and rate of geographical mobility, how often its residents move, far below those of Hennepin County and Minnesota at large. All of these factors make Greenwood a community that is hard to break into as an outsider.

By contrast Robbinsdale, another city in Hennepin county that is about 20 times the size of Greenwood, had the third highest proportion of covenants, with about 1 covenant per 4 households. Robbinsdale has a respectable proportion of black and African American residents at around 12%.

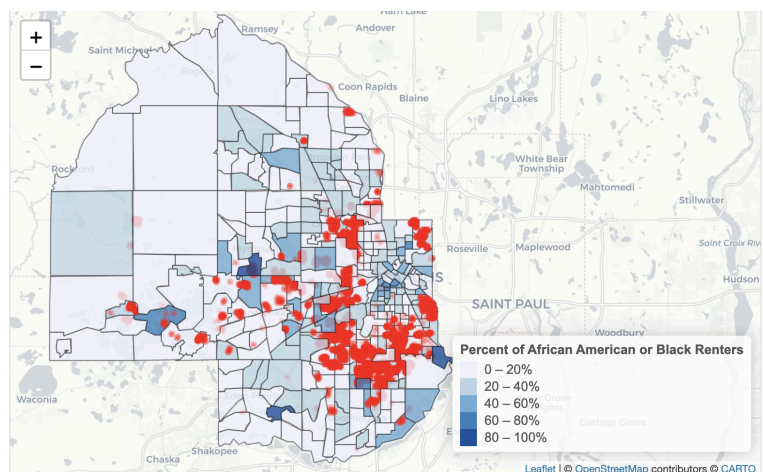
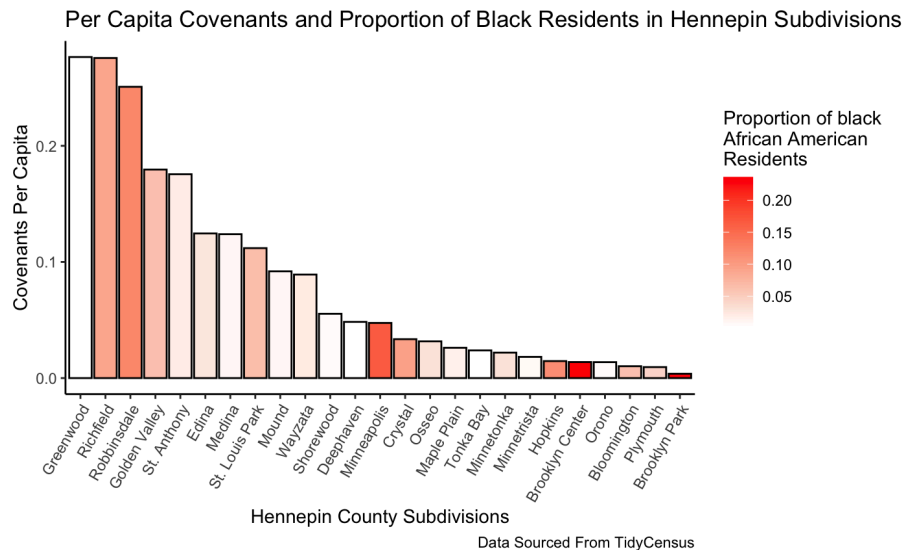
Robbinsdale is directly adjacent to Brooklyn Center, which has the highest proportion of Black/African American residents in

Hennepin county, but had only a fraction of

the per capita covenants. Here the legacy of racial covenants is also visible, but not nearly to the extent of Greenwood.

Both Robbinsdale and Brooklyn Center have much lower median home values, lower median ages, lower owner occupancy rates, and higher geographical mobility rates when compared to Greenwood. Robbinsdale and Brooklyn Center are similar in all of these metrics. The one glaring difference is that Robbinsdale had 20 times as many racial covenants per capita and half as many Black and African American Residents per capita.

Census data tracks the population of renters and homeowners by race in each census tract in Hennepin County, and it revealed that only around 11 percent of Black and African American people in the county owned their home, while around 77 percent of White people in the county own their home. The majority of census tracts in Hennepin county have a higher percentage of Black and African American renters, despite them making up an average of only 16% percent of the population in each tract. Some areas in downtown Minneapolis have a smaller gap in Black and White renters. However, there is a greater abundance of apartments and rental properties.



Homeownership is a key factor in determining the financial health and economic status of a person, as well as their overall wellbeing. Considering most Black and African American residents do not own their home, it is safe to say these residents are highly disadvantaged. This may be due to barriers in the process of buying a house due, or the overall financial inequity Black and African American people experience. However, both can be attributed to the structural racism in Hennepin County housing that has kept Black residents from owning property since the early 1900s.

The Twin Cities have the highest disparity in home ownership between white people and people of color of any major metropolitan area in the US. Through data collection and analysis of racial covenants in Minnesota, we can understand why this racial disparity exists, and work toward equality in the future.